

5.1 Cities of Awe

What does it mean to design for awe? Can this fleeting emotion be captured and tamed or must it be coaxed out and welcomed? What would a landscape rich in awe look like, and what would this abundance of awe say about its inhabitants and their relationship to this landscape? In what ways is a drive for awe reflective of a larger desire for cities and spaces to feel a certain way, rather look or perform a certain way? What might this drive for a city with an abundance ask of us and what are we willing to give to make it happen?

The hope is that this study and its accompanying framework gives practitioners a foothold to answer these questions. The work of designing for awe is no simple task. If we want awe to become a feature of urban life it will require a willingness to rethink our personal and collective relationship to time and space as well as our relationship to awareness and emotion. Given the ways in which awe manifests across different temporal registers and how it has been found to impact people’s perception of time, designing for awe will involve an integrative approach to time and space. Such an approach will meaningfully address Rhythmanalysis notions of “temporalized space” and “localized time” by honoring the multitude of temporalities—past, present, and future—embodied by human and non-human others in a given space. It will involve a greater appreciation of a sacred form of history—one that is active, lived, and celebrated—and may substantiate a further investigation of the ways in which places of awe alter individual and collective sense of time. Designing for awe will also mean navigating perceptions and prior experiences of awe. As became evident over the course of conducting this study and by various conversations about the study itself, awe is often regarded as something remarkable and is less commonly seen as a feature of everyday life. Although we certainly deserve experiences of awe like beholding the Grand Canyon or witnessing a solar eclipse, we are more likely to encounter, though perhaps less likely to notice, the unassuming experiences of awe like observing a stranger’s kindness or hearing the daily chatter of a host of sparrows. Learning to differentiate between the capital “A” forms of awe that tend to be jaw dropping, transcendent, and exceedingly evident and the lowercase “a” forms of awe that are subtle, interstitial, and unobtrusive will mean developing a greater attunement to and appreciation for the rhythms of life, no matter how vast or seemingly insignificant they might be. On a larger scale, this attunement could be achieved through educational campaigns and programming that help people to learn about the benefits of awe and that promote slowness and mindfulness as preconditions for awe. Importantly, education and programming would be oriented towards helping people to identify awe within themselves. As highlighted in this study, awe has a self reinforcing quality and can be brought to life simply by talking about it or looking for it. However, people first need to know what they are feeling internally, and must have the language to describe this inner experience. This ability to precisely identify and label emotions is known as emotional granularity and is associated with lower rates of anxiety and depression, increased emotional regulation (Kashdan et al., 2015), and great resilience through adaptive coping strategies (Tugade & Fredrickson, 2004). Designing for awe is therefore not simply a spatial project, but a cultural and emotional one that asks how urban life might better support attention, connection, meaning and emotional awareness. ab

In an attempt to design for awe, this study suggests some promising starting points. Experiences of awe can be classified and analyzed both categorically and spatially. Classifying awe may look like identifying geographies (where awe takes place), morphologies (what forms elicit awe), phenomenologies (what is the quality of the experience of awe), and temporalities (how often can this experience of awe recur). These four categories and their constituent variables offer a way to hone in on an experience of awe and determine its relative uniqueness or replicability. In aggregate, these experiences of awe can point to larger trends, or archetypes, that qualify the nature of awe in a given neighborhood or city. These patterns of awe can be further analyzed to understand where and to what degrees they are spatially clustered.

Beyond just designing *for* awe, practitioners must begin to question rational, technical models to city planning by considering how to design *with* awe. Rather than taking an extractive approach—one which relies on reproducing as much awe as possible in order to derive as much benefit as possible—we ought to consider building mutual and reciprocal relationships with the rhythms and conditions that help to elicit awe. First and foremost, designing with awe will mean increasing our sensitivity to this emotional state so that we know it when we feel it. It will involve a willingness and opportunity to slow down and attune to our embodied experiences, sensory perceptions, and personal rhythms so that we can be open to unexpected encounters and to the affective quality of our environments. However, given that there is no guarantee of feeling awe even when we are open to the experience, the best we can do is set ourselves up for success. As such, designing with awe will mean creating the conditions, or preserving existing ones, that can give rise to moments of awe. This will require providing ample opportunities for interconnection and moral beauty as well as spatial conditions like expansiveness and intimacy. It will involve an attention to detail and a willingness to invest in unnecessarily beautiful things, even if these may occasionally go unnoticed. Due to the ways in which nature is a prime elicitor of awe, creating conditions for this emotional experience will be an ecological project. More parks, trees, and green spaces will increase the likelihood of experiences of awe by inviting the rhythms of wildlife into cities. Alternatively, promoting ecological awe may be achieved creating spaces outside of cities for the rhythms of nature to flourish. This would mean upholding and re-establishing clear spatial boundaries for cities, thus providing spaces for encounters of otherness as well as opportunities to pass through an ecological-urban threshold. In addition to creating conditions for awe, we must work to honor and preserve spaces and things that are existing wellsprings of awe. This may involve a more animate form of history that celebrates decisions in the past to preserve green spaces or waterfronts, limiting encroachment on culturally and ecologically significant places, and enforcing historic preservation requirements despite current architectural trends.

Ultimately, moving from designing *for* awe to designing *with* awe will mean releasing the potential of rhythms and circumstances by attuning to what these conditions of awe ask of us. It will mean creating and sustaining relationships based on reciprocity so that the magic of awe can surface. It will mean seeing cities as emotional spaces, defined by how we want them to feel, not just how they function or what they can produce. It will mean working with our innately human capacities and embracing the potential for walking as practice “for a radical placement and displacement of self, fixing and unfixing self to urban structure,

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locational politics and cultural form” (Labelle, 2008 as cited in Edensor, 2010, p. 7). At its broadest, an awe-based approach to planning substantiates the need for an urban ethic.

Building upon Aldo Leopold’s concept of a ‘land ethic’ (Aldo Leopold Foundation, n.d.), a conviction that emphasizes the moral responsibility humans have to respect and care for biotic communities, an urban ethic fit for awe calls us to take our responsibility to the systems, spaces, and communities that constitute urban life. Informed by Keltner’s understanding that “awe enables us to see the systems underlying the wonders of life and locate ourselves in relation to them” (Keltner, 2023, p. 256), an urban ethic asks us to take responsibility for these systems so that they retain their capacity for diverse rhythms and their potential for sacredness. By embracing an urban ethic we stand to lose the sense of stability and order we’ve grown accustomed to, yet what do we stand to gain? In disrupting the monotony of everyday life, we open the possibility of a different kind of city: a city of awe – one marked by slowness, simplicity, spontaneity, and emotion, where the subtle moments of beauty, wonder, mystery, interconnection, and vastness buried just beneath the surface can finally come into view.

5.2 Finding Rhythm

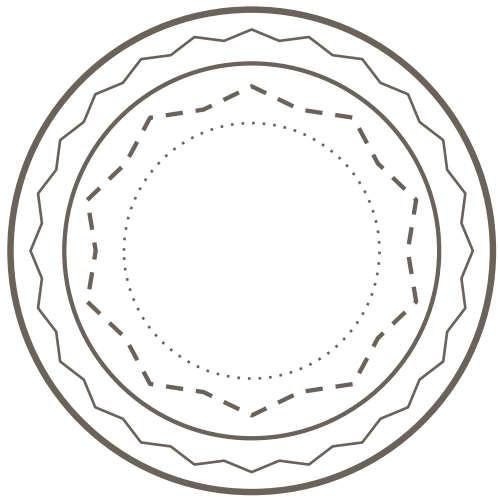
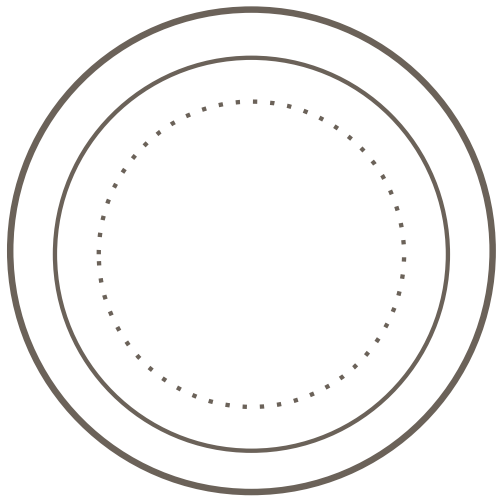
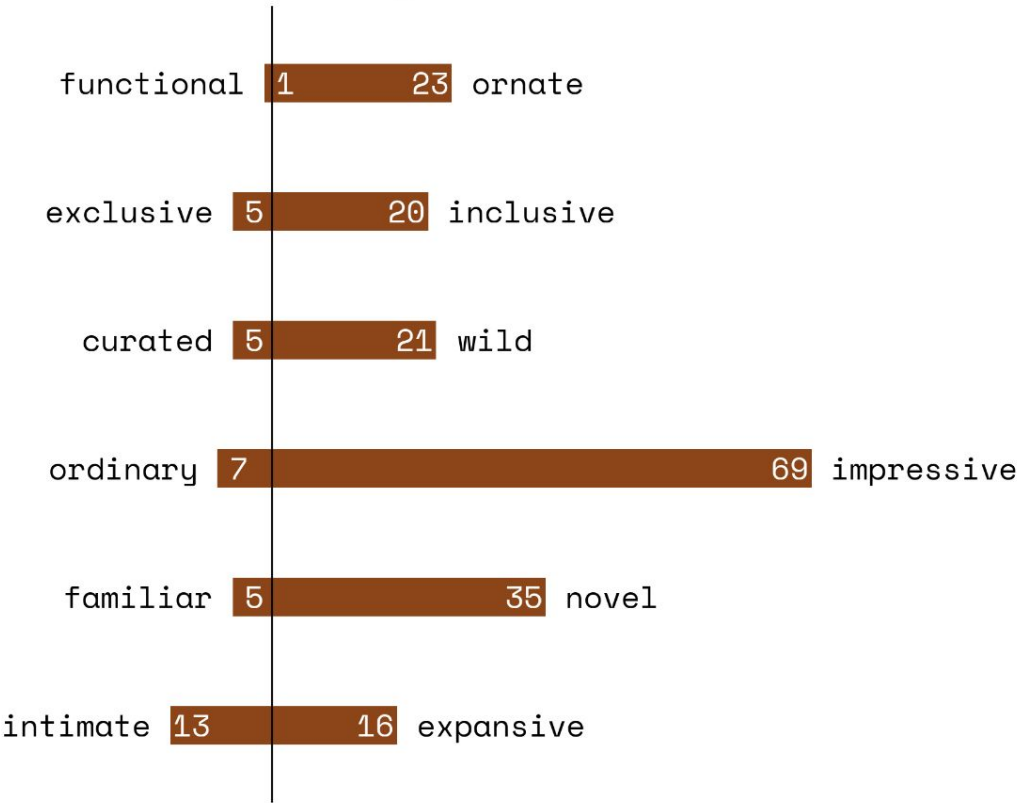
Cities are inherently polyrhythmic. Everyday urban life is composed of countless overlapping rhythms, some of which are more dynamic like diurnal patterns, weekly routines, and seasonal cycles, and some that are more stable like development, evolution, and geomorphic features. Due to the mundane and repetitive nature of everyday life as well as the slowness of more stable forms, many of these rhythms go unnoticed. Therefore, beyond simply adding new rhythms to this preexisting assemblage, awe-based planning should focus on revealing, refreshing, and reawakening the rhythms that are already present. As Keltner observes, "awe arises when we perceive change” (2023, p. 24) and through its pairing of time and space, change is what rhythmanalysis helps to make perceptible. With the help of rhythmanalysis, the task of eliciting awe is activation rather than creation—a process that relies on shifting existing rhythms and their relationships to one another.

Arriving at an understanding of how experiences of awe can benefit from subtle or significant variations in their constituent qualities came through observing and considering the tensions of awe. As participants described their experiences of awe and as these experiences were classified through the analytical framework, six phenomenological tensions began to take shape: ornate and functional, inclusive and exclusive, wild and curated, impressive and ordinary, novel and familiar, and expansive and intimate. Each tension explored a different register through which awe manifested including the formal, social, ecological, evaluative, temporal, and spatial. Together, these tensions and their corresponding registers offered a way to describe the quality or kind of awe that was routinely surfacing. What became clear, however, was that not only were these tensions expressed to varying degrees, but they also carried two distinct qualities that could be mapped onto Lefebvre’s concepts of arrhythmia (a state of disruption and discordance) and eurythmia (a state of alignment and equilibrium). Some tensions, like impressiveness or expansiveness, depended on disruption, transformation, unboundedness, and chaos, while others, like familiarity or intimacy, depended on harmony, continuity, constraint, and alignment. Thus, through the lens of rhythmanalysis, arrhythmic tensions of awe can be defined by renewal, unexpected encounters, things outside of the norm, or instances that break routine. Eurythmic tensions of awe, meanwhile, reflect repetition, slow recognition of beauty, a deepening familiarity, the rhythms of care, and details that come into view only when we slow down enough to perceive them. Importantly, both rhythms of awe arise from change: arrhythmic awe suggests a more external change often set against a stable, everyday, or normative backdrop whereas eurythmic awe suggests more subtle or internal changes, particularly as a rhythm or set of rhythms coming into alignment. Though the notions of arrhythmic and eurythmic awe help to further ground this research within the framework of rhythmanalysis, they are ultimately less a way of categorizing tensions than a way of confronting their essential qualities. They name two modes through which awe becomes perceptible and offer a lens that can be carried across the analytical framework as a whole. Rhythmically understanding a place, however, involves listening to its constituent parts—its geographies, morphologies, phenomenologies, and temporalities—regardless of whether awe is arising arrhythmically through disruption or eurhythmically through alignment.

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The work of operationalizing rhythmanalysis within the context of awe-based planning mirrors the very modes through which awe arises. Rhythmanalysis becomes the eurythmic process of seeing a place for what it is. This consists of identifying what rhythms are present, appreciating the composition of dynamic and stable forms, and acknowledging what tensions and temporalities they carry. Analyzing rhythms in this way operationalizes the conceptual framework underlying this study by tracing the geographies, morphologies, phenomenologies, and temporalities through which a place currently produces moments of awe. Rhythmactivation, by contrast, looks at sites potential for producing awe and is the more arrhythmic work of reimagining, renewing, and intervening. It involves introducing new rhythms and rhythm relationships, refreshing dormant ones, and accentuating tensions in ways that highlight the subtleties or significance of both eurythmic and arrhythmic awe. This activation of rhythms provides an opportunity to explore the interplay between vastness and accommodation and to address the ways in which “the novelty of a stimulus, and eventual habituation to it, are likely critical determinants of awe” (Piff et al., 2015, p. 896). Moreover, this practice of reimagining a place offers suggestions for how a site's rhythmic profile might be emphasized based on its strengths and how this profile might be amplified, reset, or rebalanced based on its latent potentialities. The following section provides an example of a rhythmanalysis and subsequent rhythmactivation for the Greene-Rose Heritage Park in Cambridge, MA. Though subjective in nature, these comparative diagrams demonstrate how rhythmanalysis and the analytical frameworks of this study can move from theory to practice.

Pairings of Phenomenological Tensions



Eurythmia
+
Repetition

- harmony
- continuity
- constraint
- alignment

Heuristic: Is this rhythm reinforcing, reiterating, or controlling?

Arrhythmia
+
Renewal

- disruption
- transformation
- unbounded
- chaos

Heuristic: Is this rhythm undoing, changing, or interrupting?